Concept & Uses of Classification Systems

Exam code: 0610 & 0970

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Help me understand

How Organisms are Classified

- There are millions of species of organisms on Earth
- A species is defined as a group of organisms that can **reproduce to produce fertile offspring**
- These species can be classified into groups by the **features that they share** e.g. all mammals have bodies covered in hair, feed young from mammary glands and have external ears (pinnas)

The Binomial System

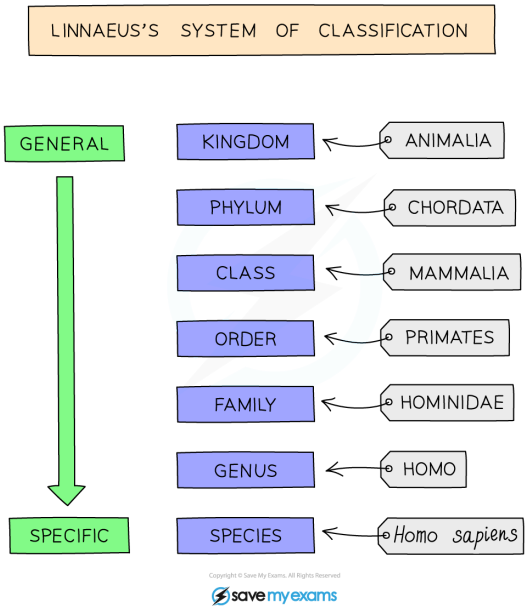
- Organisms were first classified by a Swedish naturalist called **Linnaeus** in a way that allows the subdivision of living organisms into smaller and more specialised groups
- The species in these groups have more and more features in common the more subdivided they get
- He named organisms in Latin using the **binomial system** where the scientific name of an organism is made up of two parts starting with the **genus** (always given a **capital letter**) and followed by the **species** (starting with a **lower case letter**)

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Class, **Order**, **Family**, **Genus**, **Species**



Linnaeus's system of classification

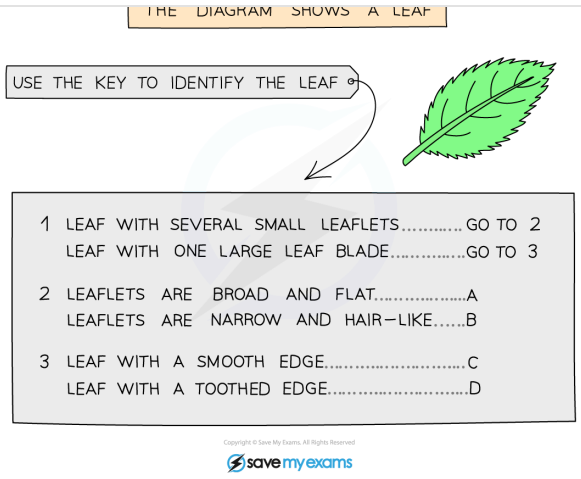
Examiner Tips and Tricks

The order of classification can be remembered by using a mnemonic like:

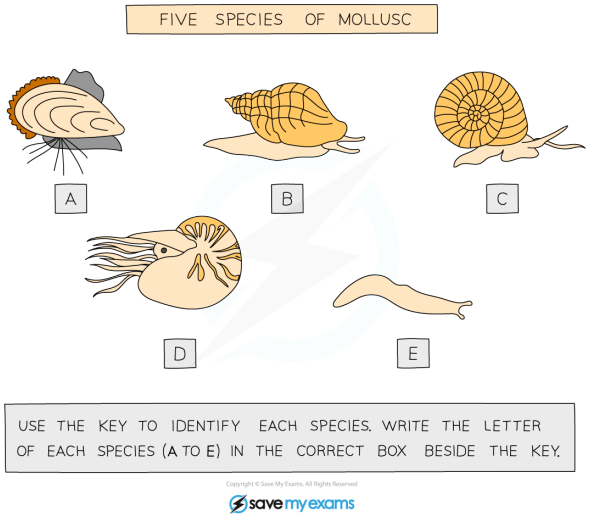
KING PHILIP CAME OVER FOR GRAN'S SPAGHETTI

Dichotomous Keys

- Keys are used to identify organisms based on a **series of questions about their features**
- Dichotomous means 'branching into two' and it leads the user through to the name of the organism by giving **two descriptions at a time** and asking them to choose
- Each choice leads the user onto another two descriptions
- In order to successfully navigate a key:
  1. You need to pick a single organism to start with, or you may be presented with an unfamiliar one as part of an exam questions
  2. **Follow the statements from the beginning**. Each statement or question you should be able to answer using the information provided in the question or an image given as part of the question.
  3. Eventually there will be no more statements or questions left and you will have the name of the organism
  4. You then pick another organism and **start at the beginning of the key again**, repeating until all



Example of a dichotomous key #1



Example of a dichotomous key #2

Examiner Tips and Tricks

do you almost always have to use one instead of constructing one, so focus on this rather than spending hours learning to construct them yourself!

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